

AAA, humanity sought. A handful of likes is worth more than a man's life

Last February, a man filmed a motorist engulfed in flames and posted the video on social media. Today, the Prosecutor's Office of Rome has closed the investigation against the author of the footage and has accused him of failure to assist. The victim of the accident died after a month of agony.

Intervention by Guido Scorza, member of the Guarantor for the protection of personal data (HuffPost, September 20, 2023)

"Did you catch fire, man?" These are the words that can be clearly heard in the background of a video capturing a man completely engulfed in flames, next to his car on the Grande Raccordo Anulare of Rome. The video was shot by a passenger in a passing car who sees a column of smoke from afar, turns on his smartphone camera, asks the driver to slow down, and begins to film the dramatic scene, later sending the footage to the managers of a very popular social media page that initially published it but then reconsidered and deleted the video, overwhelmed by negative comments and likes, probably in equal measure. It is more instinctive to film a man on fire and rush to share the footage on social media in search of likes than to stop and provide assistance.

An incredible story, if it weren't for the fact that PM Silvia Sereni of the Prosecutor's Office of Rome, having closed the investigation, has just charged the author of the video with the crime of failure to assist. He could and should have stopped to help the victim of the accident, who later died after more than a month of agony, instead of wasting time playing with his phone and chasing popularity on social media. But, aside from the legal proceedings, the story unfortunately starkly represents an increasingly widespread drift: filming every kind of atrocity instead of providing help.

Humanity overwhelmed by digital sociality. A handful of likes is worth more than a man's life.

Probably the boundary between cinematic fiction and reality has completely collapsed because it is difficult to otherwise explain what could drive a flesh-and-blood person to feel a more pressing need to film a man on fire and in danger of death than to use the same smartphone to call for help and stop to assist him.

On the other hand, in recent weeks we have read about adolescents and barely older teenagers, the authors of the group rapes in Palermo and Caivano, concerned with taking turns filming their massacre so they could later enjoy the footage and share it on social media. The need to film, document, and share, in these last cases, was even stronger than the concern of leaving evidence of conduct of unheard-of gravity.

And to the inhuman violence, there was felt the need to add another inhuman violence: filming to share, at least accepting the risk of condemning the victims to relive for eternity episodes that should, of course, not belong to anyone's life.

What has happened to humanity? Is it possible that it has been completely overwhelmed by a sub-value system in which likes count more than people? Is it possible that watching a man on fire through a smartphone or a raped girl is no longer intolerable imagery but, on the contrary, images to be captured at all costs and rushed to share? It is probably useless, in the face of certain episodes, to evoke and invoke new rules, new laws, new prohibitions.

We must come to terms with the fact, and we must do it quickly, that without a massive campaign for education on the conscious use of digital technology—more penetrating, more incisive, more widespread than the one that declared war on illiteracy in the post-war period—it is difficult even to glimpse a light at the end of the tunnel.

We cannot make it: ignorance and inhumanity, together with the power, accessibility, and usability of digital services, are the ingredients of a perfect storm that is descending upon humanity and threatening it like never before.

Educating young and old in humanity before technology, in respect for others before writing software, in human dignity before training algorithms should be considered an urgent necessity and a genuine cultural emergency.